Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on Emily Dickinson's "[A Man may make a Remark]"

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used by the contestant in a discussion of the controlling image as advice or admonition in Emily Dickinson's "[A Man may make a Remark]" include

alliteration,
anaphora,
consonance,
metaphor, and
parallelism.

The response should focus on the poem's controlling image, the potential for fire: the fuse, the spark, the gunpowder, the charcoal, the potential fire—a metaphor wherein words/speech can ignite . . . , which argues that words have consequences.

Any and all reflection upon the poem as applicable admonition—in terms of either the universal or Emily Dickinson's time period (her "writing years": 1855-1865) or a twenty-first century specific or both—should be welcomed; however, the LitCritter's analysis should dwell on the strength of the speaker's controlling image.

Any reference to Aristotelian notions of potential (e.g., wood/charcoal containing fire) recognizes the strength of the metaphor for a (potential) nineteenth century audience.